COUNTRY REPORTS: BURKINA FASO

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Status report

GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The strategy that governs Burkina Faso's digital policy expires before its replacement is due. SN@DEN, the Stratégie Nationale de Développement de l'Économie Numérique, was adopted in June 2018 and runs to 2027, while the country's commitment under its main World Bank operation is to adopt an updated digital transformation strategy, carrying a gender and disability-inclusion lens, by August 2028.

What fills the gap is a series of sectoral roadmaps and annual agendas. A national artificial-intelligence roadmap for 2026–2030, tied to the "AI for All" flagship project, went through its validation workshop in June 2026, and the government says it intends to turn that roadmap into dedicated regulation; building artificial-intelligence capability inside the central administration is presented as part of public-administration modernisation under a national digital-transformation roadmap to 2030 (July 2026). The 2025 agenda set priorities of finishing the data-centre build, extending network coverage to at least 500 underserved localities, enrolling the population for the unique identifier and launching PACTDIGITAL.

Delivery sits with the digital transition ministry, budgeted as section 31 across four programmes covering electronic-communications infrastructure, the postal sub-sector, steering and support, and digital transformation and ecosystem (2025), and the money runs largely through PACTDIGITAL, the World Bank digital acceleration operation effective from 19 September 2024. The most consequential policy of the period is not in either document: a prime-ministerial circular directs state bodies to favour national hosting, and health data need a special derogation to be hosted abroad (March 2026), the same "zero data abroad" aim that the two mini data centres are built to serve (January 2026) and that drives the repatriation of public platforms hosted offshore, which the ministry intends to complete before the end of 2026.

Legislation and regulation

Burkina Faso's Assemblée législative du peuple adopted two texts on 3 August 2026 — a substantive law on the protection of natural persons with regard to the processing of personal data, and an organic law creating ARCOD, a merged communications and data-protection regulator. The statute in force is still loi n°001-2021/AN of 30 March 2021, which replaced the 2004 law that had made the country one of Africa's earliest adopters of data protection legislation.

The rest of the digital statute book is newer and thinner than the activity around it suggests. Identification acquired a statutory base with loi n° 027-2024/ALT of 11 October 2024 on the unique electronic identification of the natural person, which the July 2026 enrolment decree is taken in application of. There is no dedicated artificial-intelligence

law, the government treating its separate roadmap as the route to one in due course. And for all the sovereignty framing around hosting, no localisation requirement is imposed in law, cross-border transfers of personal data being permitted subject to conditions and authorisation (2024).

Where the law does bite, it tends to defer the machinery. Loi n° 014-2024/ALT of 9 July 2024 on information-systems security repeals all contrary prior provisions without naming a single instrument; it also leaves the national cyberspace-control body that is to issue its approvals to be created by a later decree. Two years on, a decree of 30 July 2026 fixed the conditions for periodic security audits and for accrediting the auditors who conduct them, the first operating machinery any of those regimes has had.

Four separate ministerial permissions sit across two Burkinabè statutes — the agrément technique on the import and sale of security products, the accreditation of security auditors and the homologation of critical-infrastructure security products under the 2024 information-systems security law, and the visa statistique under the 2021 statistics law — and in every case the operating detail is left to regulation.

Data protection

The authority that supervises personal data in Burkina Faso is being merged out of existence: an organic law adopted on 3 August 2026 creates ARCOD, the Autorité de régulation de la communication et de la protection des données à caractère personnel, absorbing both the Commission de l'Informatique et des Libertés and the Conseil supérieur de la communication. The substantive personal-data law voted the same day indexes fines to turnover excluding tax, scaled to the gravity of the breach.

The existing regime is the one built on loi n°001-2021/AN of 30 March 2021, which establishes rights of consent, access, correction, erasure and redress over personal data, supervised by the Commission de l'Informatique et des Libertés, which may conduct on-site inspections and impose fines from 2 million to 100 million FCFA depending on the breach. It carries no general mandatory breach-notification obligation: a controller owes data subjects no notice after a security breach, only a limited rectification notice under article 21 (2025). Nor is there a practical route to exercise those rights against the state's own identity database, since individuals have no portal or other mechanism to view or manage the personal data ONI holds about them.

Transfers abroad run on authorisation: the commission's application form asks for the recipient, whether the destination country has a data-protection authority, the legal basis of the transfer and the data subjects' consent (September 2026).

The supervisor's own record is slight. It made no report public during 2024; the 2024 report was validated at its plenary session of 26 June 2025.

Meanwhile the processing keeps arriving. The national e-verbalisation system went live at midnight on 1 August 2026, detecting Highway Code offences by camera and notifying drivers for payment, two days before the legislature voted its supervising authority into a merger. In the other direction, a decree of 23 July 2026 on the registre national des organismes à but non lucratif fixes for the first time a retention period for those organisations' data after dissolution.

Regional collaboration

Burkina Faso's digital estate now reaches across its borders through the Alliance des États du Sahel rather than ECOWAS. It cut its ties with the bloc in 2024 together with Mali and Niger; the biometric identity card it introduced by decree of 6 November 2025 is aligned with the identity standards of the three AES states and with ICAO, and the three states launched a common AES biometric passport in January 2025.

The rupture did not extend to the money. A World Bank delegation reviewed PACTDIGITAL and WURI with the digital ministry on 4 February 2026, reporting mid-term progress on both, and Burkina Faso was still counted among the five WURI states when the programme's regional strategy on identity interoperability and mutual recognition was validated in August 2025. Customs data already crossed the southern border: the Togolese and Burkinabè customs systems began exchanging transit data between Lomé and the Bingo border office in May 2018.

The monetary union binds regardless of the bloc. Burkina Faso clears and settles through SICA-UEMOA and STAR-UEMOA, which the BCEAO operates directly, is connected to the central bank's instant payment platform PI-SPI, launched across WAEMU on 30 September 2025, and is subject to Instruction No. 001-01-2024 on payment services, in force from its signature in 2024, which imposes complaint-handling procedures, professional liability insurance and data safeguards on payment institutions. It is one of the largest parties to intra-union cross-border electronic-money payments (2024).

Regulatory harmonisation continues outside ECOWAS too. Ouagadougou hosted the West Africa Telecommunications Regulators Assembly's fourth working-groups meeting in April 2026, where the 16-regulator body finalised technical reports on 5G, subsea-cable resilience, cybersecurity, consumer protection and NGSO satellite regulation. At a UEMOA digital-economy salon in the city on 14–15 July 2026, professionals carried unanimously a proposal for an Alliance ouest-africaine des noms de domaine, to pool technical capacity, promote member states' country-code domains and give the region its own representation in international fora; in an interview published on 3 August 2026 its originator said it had still to move into an operational phase.

Standards

No Burkinabè public digital platform may go live until it has been checked against three referentials — the administration's visual identity and graphic charter, its données communes and its référentiel d'interopérabilité — which the same instrument requires to be adopted by prime-ministerial arrêté, alongside a cahier de charges and a business functional-validation report.

That instrument is décret n°2024-0922 of 2 August 2024, which reaches every digital platform of the public administration — built in-house or by a third party, acquired or received as a gift — and bars development or procurement from starting without a favourable technical opinion from the digital transition minister on the terms of reference. Where the administration bore the cost directly or indirectly, the supplier or in-house team must assign full rights in the source code and all current documentation to the state before the platform enters service. Going live also requires an avis de non objection from the information-systems security body, obtained on a security-test report, and a platform operated in breach is suspended on the minister's request.

How much of that architecture is shared practice is another question. The government interoperability framework and data-exchange arrangement are in place but only partially used across government (2025), and there is no electronic government procurement system, nor any of the four e-procurement functions the index tracks (2025). A Manual of Procedures for the Management of Information Systems was validated in September 2025 as a harmonised reference framework for government information systems. The national standards agency ABNORM is the country's ISO member body, participating in nine technical committees and observing five, with food, electrotechnical, environmental and building standards as its priority sectors (October 2026). Beyond government, the clearest published standard is the certified electronic invoice, launched in January 2026.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

Organised dissent is being suspended outright. The law on freedom of association of July 2025 had been invoked to suspend or dissolve 1,174 organisations from mid-April to 11 June 2026, the largest student union was suspended on 26 May after criticising the government's security record, and the communication regulator suspended TV5 Monde indefinitely on 5 May; it was the channel's third suspension after two in 2024. The intelligence agency took editors from their newsrooms in October 2025, releasing them within days.

Room for public argument has closed faster in Burkina Faso than almost anything else the governance indices measure. Civil Society Space is the country's third most deteriorated IIAG indicator of the decade, down 39.8 points over 2014–2023 to 59.7 out of 100, 22nd of 54 (2023); over the same decade Media Freedom fell 25.3 points to 53.4 and Freedom of Expression & Belief 31.1 points to 64.9, and Digital Freedom fell 16.5 points to 45.3, 32nd of 54 (2023).

Consultation has followed, if less steeply: the index's Deliberative & Participatory Governance measure fell 8.6 points over 2014–2023 to 62.6, 20th of 54 (2023). There is no digital machinery standing in for it: Burkina Faso has no government e-participation platform and none of the five further participation mechanisms the index tracks (2025), and no central citizen feedback or grievance-redress platform for public services (2025). The Commission Électorale Nationale Indépendante was dissolved in July 2025 and its responsibilities, including custody of the register, passed to the Ministry of Territorial Administration, with no elections scheduled before 2029.

The formal channel that remains is the 2015 access-to-information law, and its enforcement body is weak by design: ANAIP issues only an avis, after which a public body has ten days to say what it has done and its silence confirms the refusal, while binding relief — production of the document, annulment of the refusal, an injunction under astreinte — lies solely with the administrative tribunal, referral to ANAIP being a compulsory precondition to going there. Regulation of speech has moved the other way: an organic law of 2023 extended the broadcast regulator's reach to social-media accounts above a follower threshold, and the organic law adopted on 3 August 2026 would place broadcast-content regulation and personal-data supervision under one authority.

Finance

Financial sustainability

Burkina Faso's 2026 finance law gives the digital ministry 23.3 billion FCFA of grant and loan capital, all of it in the WURI identity programme and PACTDIGITAL, against 1.24 billion FCFA of investment the state finances alone, up from 15.4 billion FCFA of external capital in the 2025 law.

The domestic-state share of the digital lines in Burkina Faso's finance laws, at the appropriated stage, fell from 56.2% for 2024 to 52.0% for 2025 and 39.8% for 2026, as the domestically financed lines eased from 18.2 billion to 15.4 billion FCFA while the externally financed side grew.

The largest domestic line of 2025 was a software debt: the 2025 law set 4.09 billion FCFA of domestic revenue to pay arrears under the state's agreement with Microsoft, more than all the ministry's other state-only investment together, and the 2026 law carries no such line. Smaller running costs sit on the state's own revenue: licence renewals for the police cybercrime brigade rose to 40 million FCFA in 2026 from 20 million, and operating the two government data centres was costed at about 500 million FCFA over their first three years (January 2026).

What is voted is not what is spent. Of 6.64 billion FCFA of domestic investment voted to the digital ministry for 2025, 2.09 billion remained after in-year adjustment, and that was spent in full.

The one own-source mechanism on record is the universal service fund: FASU co-finances the 2026 push to connect 750 unserved localities alongside PACTDIGITAL, with Onatel, Orange Burkina Faso and Telecel each called on to co-finance on equal terms with the state (September 2026). The external windows close soon — WURI in 2027 and PACTDIGITAL in 2028 — and no plan to carry the systems they finance on the recurrent budget had been published as at September 2026.

MoUs and other agreements

Burkina Faso had signed no memorandum of understanding or comparable non-binding digital cooperation agreement as at August 2026.

New investments

Burkina Faso's only foundational-identity financing on record comes through a regional programme: the World Bank's second phase of West Africa Unique Identification for Regional Integration and Inclusion, a USD 273 million operation shared with Benin, Niger and Togo, 2020–2027.

The largest single commitment is the World Bank's Digital Acceleration Project, USD 150 million running 2024–2028, covering broadband, digital government and digital financial services. Approved on 23 January 2024, it became effective only that September, and it anchors PACTDIGITAL-BF, twelve flagship projects running to 2030 on World Bank IDA money alongside national funding (March 2026).

The Bank's earlier digital lending has run its course: USD 30 million for economic governance and GovTech work with the Ministry of Territorial Administration and Decentralisation, 2016–2022; USD 20 million in additional financing for regional communications infrastructure, to 2021; and USD 28.3 million of a USD 100 million financial-inclusion operation for digitising government-to-person payments and microfinance, whose coordinator set out its results after seven years of implementation in June 2026.

Eleven digital commitments naming Burkina Faso are on record across 2016–2028, worth roughly USD 435 million equivalent, six still active (2026). The World Bank accounts for four of them and about USD 228 million (2026). Some USD 406 million of the whole is loans and credits, against about USD 8 million in grants and one public-private partnership at about USD 21 million, while connectivity and fibre-heavy ICT-industry work take roughly USD 371 million of it (2026).

Chinese state lenders are the largest bilateral source: a China Eximbank concessional loan of RMB 560 million for Smart Burkina Faso and a Bank of China buyer's credit of USD 77.35 million for the national fibre backbone, together roughly two-fifths of all recorded digital commitments, both with Huawei as contractor (2026).

ARCEP's first phase of the "white zones" universal-service programme, a public-private partnership awarded by tender to Orange Burkina Faso, installed 183 mobile sites for a little over XOF 13 billion, most of it borne by the operator (2022). The European Union's indicative envelope of EUR 384 million for 2021–2024 sets nothing aside for digital, which sits among the programme's transversal themes rather than its priority areas.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

About a fifth of the population used the internet in early 2024, and what connection there is comes expensive: mobile internet costs 8.8 per cent of gross national income per capita, against an African average of 5.32 per cent (2025). Mobile connections outnumber people (January 2025), and the ITU's ICT Development Index placed Burkina

Faso at 30.1 out of 100 in 2024, 43rd of 47 African countries. Connection is also conditional on identification, since an operator must refuse service to anyone who does not present an identity document such as a national identity card or passport (2018).

The direction is better than the level. Mobile Communications is Burkina Faso's most improved of the 96 indicators in the Ibrahim Index of African Governance, up 29.6 points over 2014-2023 to 58.6 out of 100, and still only 39th of 54 African countries (2023). The index's Internet & Computers indicator moved almost as fast, up 21.4 points to 24.3 out of 100 (2023), the fifth largest gain of the 96 and from a base low enough that the level stays near the bottom of the continent. Infrastructure as a whole is the country's worst-scoring of the index's sixteen sub-categories at 31.6 out of 100 (2023) and at the same time its most improved.

Outside the towns, coverage is extended through a universal-service programme run by the regulator ARCEP as a public-private partnership, awarded by tender to Orange Burkina Faso, whose first phase was complete by 2022 and left thousands of localities with no mobile network at all.

An internet exchange point, BFIX, operates with sites in Ouagadougou and Bobo-Dioulasso (2024). The state's own network is the weak point: RESINA, built out since 2007 around a fibre backbone with WiMAX stations, IP telephony, DNS and DHCP, was named by the budget directorate among the obstacles to executing the 2025 state budget. A replacement had its architecture settled and its equipment bids under evaluation as at July 2026. Connectivity is where the external money has gone, through the World Bank's Digital Acceleration Project running to 2028 and the closed WARCIP broadband operation before it.

The minister put 3,140 public buildings on the national administration network on 8 October 2026, against 2,332 in the state ICT agency's 2020 report.

The minister said on 8 October 2026 that 750 villages with no network will be connected by end-2026 and 750 more by 2028, on FCFA 25bn mobilised by the State, under a target of no white zones by 2030.

Data Storage

Burkina Faso has begun physically repatriating its public data: 120 public digital platforms hosted outside the country have been inventoried and their migration into the two national data centres started, with completion intended before the end of 2026 under the « Zéro donnée à l'extérieur » policy (July 2026). The inventory is not finished, the digital transition minister stating that investigations continue to identify platforms not yet on the list.

The receiving capacity was commissioned in January 2026. Two mini data centres, built at 16 billion FCFA — about US$28.6 million — provide around 3,000 TB of storage and over 7,000 virtual machines, roughly ten times the country's prior capacity (January 2026), and are treated as an interim step toward a planned national data centre. A Digital Infrastructure Supervision Centre budgeted at about US$5.4 million and due around October 2026 is to centralise oversight of the national backbone, the data centres and cyberspace. At a ministerial site visit on 5 August 2026 the technical managers put physical execution across the worksite of the Centre d'opération du Réseau Backbone national, which is to monitor the national fibre network, and the first citizen service centre together at about 20%.

Who must host where is set mainly by policy. A Prime Ministerial circular directs state bodies to favour national hosting, health data needing a special derogation to be hosted abroad (March 2026), while the general framework imposes no data localisation requirement and permits cross-border transfers of personal data subject to conditions and authorisation (2024).

ANPTIC operates a government cloud at cloud.gov.bf with eight cloud nodes across four datacentres, offering infrastructure, platform and software services to 354 connected communes (2026), though no cloud-first or cloud adoption policy is in place (2025). Commercial local hosting is newer: IKA Solution launched IKA CLOUD in Ouagadougou on 31 July 2026 under the patronage of the ministry responsible for digital transition, selling to firms, start-ups, individuals and public institutions. The digital-transition minister put the national data centre planned for 2028 at an estimated FCFA 20bn on 8 October 2026.

Energy

Two per cent of Burkina Faso's rural population had access to electricity in 2023, against 62.6 per cent of the urban population, a gap of about 61 percentage points and the sharpest single constraint on carrying anything digital beyond the towns. Nationally, electricity reached 21.7 per cent of the population (2023), and Access to Energy is among the ten worst-scoring of the Ibrahim Index's 96 indicators for the country at 16.3 out of 100, 45th of 54, having gained only 4.4 points over 2014-2023.

Supply is unreliable where it exists: firms report about eight electrical outages a month (2024), roughly weekly interruption. It is also dear against income. The national utility SONABEL charges residential customers on an increasing block tariff, at roughly XOF 75 per kWh for the first 50 kWh each month and about XOF 128 to 138 per kWh above that (2024). Renewable sources, chiefly hydropower alongside expanding utility-scale solar, accounted for 13.92 per cent of generation in 2021.

The framework for decentralised electrification is the strong part of the picture: Burkina Faso scores highly on RISE for its off-grid and mini-grid enabling environment, with dedicated institutions and a policy framework for decentralised electrification (2024). Set against the 2 per cent of the rural population with access to electricity in 2023, that framework has yet to reach the ground.

Technical Capacity

Burkina Faso's administration ranks far higher than its infrastructure does. Public Administration is the third best-scoring of the Ibrahim Index's sixteen sub-categories for the country at 64.0 out of 100, 11th of 54 (2023), and Effective Administration stands at 66.4 out of 100, 12th of 54, though down 3.2 points over 2014-2023. Budgetary and financial management, one of the country's strongest measures of all, has slipped over the same decade.

The clearest test of operating capacity so far is that the two mini data centres commissioned in January 2026 are run by national teams rather than by a foreign operator. Building and supplying systems is a different matter. Identity production depends on foreign suppliers — remote assistance and training from a Canadian firm for the identity card and a French firm for the iCivil bubble tags, with police and gendarmerie officers running day-to-day operations in country — and the country's passport is supplied by the Chinese firm Emptech (2025).

The state is regularising the last staff of its first informatics body: the Council of Ministers of 23 July 2026 made board appointments at ANPTIC and authorised the transfer into the civil service of the remaining contract staff of the former CENATRIN, the data-processing centre created in 1970 and liquidated in 2005.

Cybersecurity

Burkina Faso's cybersecurity statute got its operating machinery two years after it passed. Two decrees adopted on 30 July 2026 identify and classify the country's organismes à infrastructures critiques — any entity housing installations, works or systems indispensable to the vital functions of society, expressly spanning energy, water, health, telecommunications and the financial sector — and fix the conditions for periodic security audits of information systems and for accrediting the auditors who conduct them. Loi n° 014-2024/ALT of 9 July 2024 had created three separate permissions — accreditation of auditors, homologation of the security products used by

critical-infrastructure bodies, and an agrément technique conditioning any importation or sale of security hardware or software — and left the national cyberspace-control body that issues all three to be created by decree, naming no agency.

Two years and three weeks separated the enactment of the three licensing regimes from the decrees that let any of them operate.

The statute leads its governing principles with «sécurité et sauvegarde de la souveraineté nationale», ahead of proportionality, equal treatment and technological neutrality, and places critical infrastructure of military interest under the defence ministry rather than the civilian cyberspace body, which also gave existing approvals one year from entry into force to conform. Penalties run from 1 million to 100 million FCFA, a repeat audit failure reaching 1 to 5 per cent of an organisation's last closed turnover and other repeat offences at least double the previous fine.

What the machinery is against is measured, on two counts that do not sit together: the cybercrime unit puts reported loss at about FCFA 1.7bn in 2025 and FCFA 906,123,245 in the first half of 2026, on more than a thousand complaints in that half year, while an August account of the same unit's figures gives 6,367 complaints and FCFA 1.872bn of losses for 2025.

Separately, no public digital platform may go live without an avis de non objection from the information-systems security body, obtained by submitting a security-test report. The country sits in the "Establishing" tier of the ITU's Global Cybersecurity Index 2024, for scores of 55 to 85; an information-systems security agency, ANSSI, has existed since 2018, and the Brigade centrale de lutte contre la cybercriminalité is operating as an active cybercrime unit, taking a SIM-registration fraud case to an arrest at Kombissiri in August 2026. There is no general mandatory breach notification duty, the personal data law requiring no notice to data subjects after a security breach (2025).

DPI

Data Exchange

Burkina Faso has no working national exchange layer: data exchange between government institutions is not operational at national scale, systems remain largely siloed and the interoperability layer is still under active development (2025). The ministry developed sixty-nine new digital platforms for public services during 2025.

What crosses between systems crosses point to point, and the clearest working case is enforcement rather than service delivery. The traffic-enforcement chain is interconnected across the DGTTM vehicle database, the e-Contravention system launched in 2023 and the Faso Arzeka payments platform, converging on a national supervision centre presented by the Ministry of Security in late July 2026. Elsewhere the links are single-purpose or still planned: the tax authority's 2025–2027 operational plan sets a target of interconnecting seventeen of its sites over the RESINA administrative network, the regional credit bureau takes data from only 20 of the 120 microfinance institutions licensed at the end of 2025, those above FCFA 2bn of savings or credit, client consent now being required, and iCivil links maternity wards to the central civil registration database, letting a midwife register a birth from a smartphone against a unique identifier (2022).

The joins that would matter most are the ones missing. There is no formal interoperability between the ONI identity database and the civil registry, the electoral commission, or health and tax systems, no unique identifier shared across them (2017), and work on connecting the social registry to the unique identifier under development has begun with World Bank support without being implemented (2025). The direction of travel has not been uniform either: CEFORE left the shared Système Intégré des Guichets Uniques, which had loosely connected the land,

construction and business one-stop shops since 2016, for its own standalone module in April 2022. A référentiel d'interopérabilité is now among the conformity documents a public platform must satisfy before the digital transition minister clears it into service.

Digital Identity and CRVS

Burkina Faso has replaced its national identity card: the Office national d'identification introduced the Carte d'Identité Biométrique de l'AES on 1 December 2025, under a decree of 6 November 2025, replacing the CNIB, with mass production beginning in January 2026 and a five-year transition for withdrawing the cards then in circulation. The CNIB was a Teslin card with a barcode that no government portal authenticated anyone with, leaving banks to verify identity by inspecting the plastic (2024). It is issued from age 5 and compulsory from 13, against 15 before (2025), and carries Alliance of Sahel States branding, Burkina Faso being the first of the three states to adopt it and Niger following on 27 March 2026.

Coverage is the weak point. The centralised electronic database held some 7.2 million active cards (2015), deduplicated on demographic similarity and fingerprints from the start and on facial biometrics since 2009, and the World Bank's diagnostic found most adults holding a card, with total population coverage materially lower given the size of the under-15 population (2017). Individuals have no self-service route to see or manage what the database holds about them (2024).

The electronic identifier is a separate and slower track. A law on unique electronic identification of natural persons was adopted in October 2024, tying the future number to the CNIB, the passport and other records; the Conseil des ministres adopted a decree on 30 July 2026 organising mass registration for it under the WURI programme, run through national, regional, provincial and communal committees with complaint-handling machinery, with enrolment carried out entirely by public structures so that fingerprint and iris data stay in national custody.

The state has named where it wants the chain to reach next: the security minister made the securing of academic and professional diplomas the theme of the seventh International Identity Day on 16 September 2026, setting the aim as a centralised national interoperability and trust framework that leaves academic prerogatives with the institutions while making the production and verification chain tamper-proof; no instrument, operator or timetable is published for it. What a card is accepted for remains narrow and paper-checked. A valid CNIB or passport is required to open a bank account (2025), and since a decree of 15 December 2023 the national identity card is the only document a citizen may use to buy a SIM, with at most two SIMs per operator. The check is only as good as the counter: a SIM reseller was arrested at Kombissiri in August 2026 for registering lines against identity documents sent to him over WhatsApp, without the holder present. The digital-transition minister said on 8 October 2026 that enrolment for the digital identity, budgeted at over FCFA 40bn, was due to start that month.

Digital Payments and Fintech

Burkina Faso is second only to Côte d'Ivoire in intra-WAEMU cross-border electronic-money payments sent and received, with 22 million operations worth 1,459 billion FCFA in 2024, yet it holds only 9.53% of the electronic-money accounts opened across the union, fourth behind Côte d'Ivoire, Senegal and Benin (2024).

That makes the country the carrier of roughly a quarter of the value of all cross-border mobile money moving inside the union while holding under a tenth of its accounts — a corridor economy rather than a deep domestic market.

The domestic market is growing and losing ground at once. Account ownership at a financial institution or with a mobile money provider reached 51.4% of adults (2024) and transaction volumes grew 21.04% over the year, ahead of Côte d'Ivoire and behind Senegal, but Burkina Faso's share of union electronic-money volume fell to 18.2% and of value to 12.6%, from 19.7% and 12.8% in 2023.

The rails and rules are regional. The BCEAO operates the SICA-UEMOA clearing system and the STAR-UEMOA settlement system, and launched the interoperable instant payment platform PI-SPI across all member states on 30 September 2025, for round-the-clock transfers between banks, microfinance institutions and electronic money issuers. Instruction No. 001-01-2024, in force from its signature in 2024, imposes complaint-handling procedures, professional civil liability insurance and security safeguards on payment institutions.

The state is now on these rails itself. Faso Arzêka lets citizens pay taxes, duties and administrative charges by app or USSD (2024), and more than 16,000 CARFO and CNSS pensioners were receiving their pensions by mobile money (June 2026), and safety-net transfers had been paid by mobile money since 2018 when a 2023 study found illiterate recipients sharing their PINs with agents and cashing out in full. The treasury is one of only two in the union authorised to issue electronic money, from August 2024, and the instrument approved is a prepaid card rather than a wallet — the regional rulebook confines a treasury scheme to a closed network of the state's own allocation beneficiaries, delegated through GIM-UEMOA. Payment is becoming compulsory too: an automated traffic fine is served by SMS with a payment link to Faso Arzeka, and non-payment within a month can have the vehicle immobilised at a roadside check or at technical inspection (August 2026).

Registries

The social registry is the register moving fastest: 362,698 households and 2,217,518 people were enrolled in the Registre Social Unique across 99 of Burkina Faso's 351 communes in January 2026, up from 79, with each registered person carrying a unique identification code under the National Social Protection Strategy 2024–2028, and its secretariat committed in April and May 2025 to including refugees.

Civil registration is the slowest. Only 60.65% of births are registered within the legal deadline (2024); thirty communes held fully digitised civil-status registers by the end of 2025; and the iCivil notification system operates at around 130 of 2,584 vital-event notification points (2024). The VENEEM platform, piloted from June 2024 in Komsilga and one Ouagadougou arrondissement, assigns a civil-status identifier at the point of registration, and a draft Code des personnes et de la famille before the Transitional Legislative Assembly would give digital civil registers legal standing (2025). Displacement drives much of the output: 121,000 civil-status documents went to internally displaced people in 2025, nearly double the 65,000 target.

The economic registers are online but shallow. The Fichier National du RCCM went online in December 2023 and offers free public search of 80,604 registered businesses (2026), against an economy the 2024 general business census found overwhelmingly informal; the transactional service for extracts covers only businesses registered with the Ouagadougou commercial court (2023), though CEFORE issues the register number and the tax identifier in one transaction. SyC@D, the integrated land, cadastre and state-domain platform, launched on 21 March 2025, and Ouagadougou's EU-supported street-addressing programme moved on to arrondissements 5 and 12 in April 2025, after arrondissements 1 and 2.

The biometric electoral register, audited in October 2020 at 6,490,926 voters, passed to the Ministry of Territorial Administration when the electoral commission was dissolved in July 2025, with no elections scheduled before 2029. A decree of 23 July 2026 redrew the register of non-profit organisations, grounding it in the anti-money-laundering law of December 2024 and fixing for the first time how long data are kept after dissolution.

Sectoral management information systems

Burkina Faso's line ministries run central systems that nothing feeds at the point of service. Rural primary healthcare clinics record consultations on paper registers, which health workers summarise monthly onto paper forms for district teams to key into DHIS2 (2026), and a tablet tool evaluated in one rural district ran alongside paper reporting rather than replacing it. Primary schools follow the same shape: directors complete paper forms on a fixed annual

census day, physically routed to district and regional education offices where staff enter them into the STATEDUC 2 application (2024), and the education ministry set out in December 2024 to renovate its management information system through a pupil file, online enrolment, school identity cards and a geo-referenced school census. Police stations and gendarmerie brigades keep their incident logs in physical registers, which a computerised platform is being built to replace (2023).

Above that, the systems are real. Financial management, treasury, tax, customs, human resources, payroll, social insurance and debt management are all recorded as in use, with electronic procurement the one core system absent (2025): the financial management system runs at central and sub-national level across treasury and budget functions, the pension and social insurance system has a separate track for public employees, and a treasury single account is used extensively by all ministries, departments and agencies.

Most are built to order rather than bought in: five of the seven core systems — financial management, tax, human resources, payroll and social insurance — run custom software, against commercial off-the-shelf products for customs and debt management.

The revenue side has the clearest plans for connection. The tax administration's 2025–2027 operational plan sets actions to interconnect seventeen of its sites over the state network and to upgrade its interface with the national statistics institute, the tax directorate launched two in-house platforms in October 2023, eTITRE for land-occupation titles in Ouagadougou and Bobo-Dioulasso and eCME for online assessment of micro-enterprises, and an integrated eCustoms payment platform launched in December 2023 is to let importers pay duties by a choice of methods (2024). Elsewhere the links are few and single-purpose: the SIGASPE civil-service database is linked to the identity card's biometric database to authenticate anyone working as a civil servant (2017), a national pupil file with online enrolment and school identity cards was under review with WURI support, progressive enrolment due from the following school year (June 2025), and the employment agency's online recruitment platform gives each jobseeker a unique identifier (2021). A conference paper reported the OpenClinic pilot at the Manga regional hospital ending in full digitisation of admissions and use of the electronic patient record across departments (2026).

Other GovTech and e-Gov

The most consequential thing the Burkinabè state now does online it does to citizens rather than for them: automated camera enforcement of the Highway Code went live at midnight on 1 August 2026, and by noon the supervision centre had detected 1,099 offences — no seatbelt, red lights, speeding, phone at the wheel — of which five had been paid. The cameras, piloted in Ouagadougou since 7 April, run artificial-intelligence algorithms that read plates and match them to owners through the state vehicle database.

As service delivery, the position is thinner. The UN E-Government Development Index put Burkina Faso at 0.2895, 175th of 193 states (2024), the national government service portal is informational rather than transactional and none of the six portal capabilities the index tracks are in place (2025), there is no electronic government procurement system at all — bidders have obtained the certificates public procurement requires online through SECOP since June 2025, the finance minister promising full electronic procurement, a goal a World Bank e-procurement project has carried since 2022 — and no central citizen feedback, grievance-redress or e-participation platform.

What works, works service by service. Taxpayers file declarations including VAT through the eSINTAX portal, register, file and pay tax online (2025), and a certified electronic invoice was launched in January 2026. A national electronic criminal record service runs at ecasier-judiciaire.gov.bf (2025), joined in December 2025 by online criminal complaint and case tracking, a prison visit permit service and an online commercial register service, six

months after the justice and digital ministries reset the scope of a 2025-2027 project to digitise criminal procedure. Citizens can request birth, marriage and death extracts online (2025), and public agents have been able to file retirement formalities through the eCARFO portal since 21 July 2026.

Since 15 September the administration has had a signature layer under those services: FasoSign was launched already integrated into the mission-order, administrative-mail and cadastre platforms, its keys and certificates presented as held by the state itself, with no signature count or adoption list published. On the tax side the certified invoice reached its products rather than its rule: certified invoicing systems went on sale from 7 September 2026, twenty months after the order that established it.

The construction ministry's e-demarcheur platform, launched on 21 July 2026, issues the licence an April 2026 arrêté makes compulsory for anyone brokering residential leases, wholly online; the card is valid as a virtual credential from the moment of validation, before any plastic is printed, and the register behind it can be queried by the public by number or QR code. Behind these sits a pipeline the public cannot yet fully reach: 220 business licences have been moved online through a state platform generator, the ministry still working with the line agencies to make them fully accessible (July 2026).

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

The government ICT agency's cloud at cloud.gov.bf runs on eight cloud nodes across four datacentres and serves 354 connected communes (2026), while thirty communes held fully digitised civil-status registers at the end of 2025. The pattern below the national level is of national systems reaching down rather than local ones reaching up: the enrolment decree of 30 July 2026 requires the biometric registration operation to be run entirely by public structures, with fingerprints and iris data kept in national custody, and delivers it through national, regional, provincial and communal committees, the communal tier serving as the delivery machinery of a central programme.

The clearest municipal data of a commune's own making is in the capital, and it is financed from outside: Ouagadougou launched EU-supported street addressing in arrondissements 5 and 12 in April 2025, after arrondissements 1 and 2, covering more than 2,277 streets and 43,000 doors, to build an address database for water, electricity, postal, fire and cadastre services. The dedicated external money is spent: the World Bank's USD 30 million Economic Governance, GovTech and Citizen Engagement project, working with the Ministry of Territorial Administration and Decentralisation on GovTech solutions, digital public services and digital accountability tools, ran from 2016 to 2022 and has closed. Activity since has been at the ministry rather than in the communes, senior staff there being trained in personal data protection in July 2025. The one physical local presence being built follows the same pattern: the first Maison du citoyen, named Zama Tchey and under construction at a ministerial visit on 5 August 2026, is to bring postal, financial and digital services closer to the population and is delivered by the state and the postal service rather than by a commune. The digital-transition minister said 80 Maisons du citoyen had been launched on a FCFA 10bn government envelope, against a target of one in each of the 351 communes by 2030 (2026).

Rural digital data capture

Records made outside Burkina Faso's towns are made on paper and become digital only after they leave the place they were made: in primary care, health workers write consultations into paper registers and summarise them monthly onto forms that district teams key into DHIS2 (2026). Primary schools work the same way, with directors completing paper forms on a fixed annual census day that are routed physically through the basic-education

circonscriptions and the regional directorates, where staff enter them into the STATEDUC 2 application (2024). Police stations and gendarmerie brigades keep their incident logs in physical registers, which a computerised platform is being built to replace (2023).

What has been digitised is either the archive or a pilot. Under the national civil registration strategy, main civil registry centres were networked and millions of archival civil-status records digitised and secured during 2024 — back-capture of records already written by hand, not registration as the event occurs. An application built by Burkinabè engineers to register vital events was still awaiting deployment (June 2025). A tablet tool evaluated at the point of care in one rural district ran in parallel with paper reporting rather than replacing it (2019–2021). The conditions for capture in the field are thin: rural electricity access is a small fraction of the urban rate (2023), and insecurity had knocked out electronic-communications networks in parts of the country, the state putting more than 3 billion CFA francs into restoring them (March 2025).

This is not a story of rural policy neglect: Rural Economy is Burkina Faso's best-scoring Ibrahim Index sub-category at 67.8 out of 100, 15th of 54 (2023) and rural representation and participation is one of its ten best indicators at 78.2 (2023), though rural market access has fallen 14.5 points since 2014, to 69.3 (2023).

Technology

AI

Burkina Faso validated a national artificial-intelligence roadmap for 2026–2030 in June 2026, meant to align with the government's RELANCE plan and support its "AI for All" flagship, and the UEMOA Commission counts it among the four union members holding a national strategy (July 2026). A ministry workshop in March 2026 set out to build large-language-model data corpora in Mooré, Dioula, Fulfuldé and Gulmancema for speech recognition, automatic translation and voice synthesis. That direction — putting national languages at the core of the country's AI development — has been consistent since the ministry's planning opened with a consultation workshop on a 2026–2028 AI action plan (September 2025) around six focus areas including data governance and infrastructure.

The roadmap is a policy document and not an instrument: there is no dedicated artificial-intelligence law, and the government's stated answer on AI inside the personal-data law adopted on 3 August 2026 is that law's prohibition on transferring sensitive personal data abroad — a rule about where data sits rather than about how it is processed. The new communications regulator was separately given its own rule-making power, which the government argued would let it keep pace with technology, naming artificial intelligence.

Deployment is narrower than the plan. Automated traffic enforcement entered operation on 1 August 2026, running high-definition cameras in Ouagadougou, piloted since April, with AI algorithms that detect four categories of offence, read number plates and match them to registered owners through the DGTTM vehicle database, serving the fine by SMS with a payment link to the Faso Arzeka wallet and immobilising the vehicle if it goes unpaid for a month. The digital ministry and the state broadcaster agreed in October 2025 to use AI for public information, including a tool translating Mooré into French. Away from that, the estate is research and training: CITADEL, the AI centre of the Université Virtuelle du Burkina Faso, in a second, research-oriented phase since April 2025, and a two-day session the Prime Minister's office ran for its own senior staff on 13–14 July 2026 on ethical and responsible use.

ICT Industry

The measurable software base is small: a public listing of GitHub contributors by country places the Burkinabè developer community in the low hundreds (2025). Beyond that the sector is not counted — Burkina Faso has conducted no business or establishment survey within the last ten years (2023), which leaves the firm-level economy,

digital firms included, without a statistical base. The wider export economy has narrowed alongside it: economic diversification is among the ten most deteriorated indicators in the country's governance profile, down 22.0 points over 2014–2023 to 26.9 out of 100 and 51st of 54 (2023).

What the state and the large operators run is largely bought in. The mining cadastre's eMC+ system was upgraded by the contractor GAF AG under a World Bank-funded governance project (2025), and Orange Money's Burkinabè operation runs on Comviva's Mobiquity Pay X platform (March 2025). Domestic supply is starting at the edges: IKA Solution, a Burkinabè firm founded in 2014, launched a data-hosting service in Ouagadougou on 31 July 2026 under the patronage of the ministry responsible for digital transition, sold to firms, start-ups, individuals and public institutions. Firms of any kind work against frequent interruptions to electricity supply (2024), and any import or sale of security hardware or software is conditional on a technical approval from the national cyberspace-control body.

Innovation ecosystem

Burkina Faso ranks 129th of 133 economies in the Global Innovation Index 2024, in the index's bottom tier. Under the ranking sits a real but thin apparatus: several innovation hubs and fab labs, among them OuagaLab, InViis Lab and La Fabrique (2023), and the Faso Andubè platform, launched to promote local innovation (2025). Domestic products do come out of it — YENGA, built by the Burkinabè firm KREEZUS, aggregates three mobile operators and five wallets in a single payment interface (March 2026).

Money to grow them is thin: the Agence Française de Développement's AFIDBA call for projects on social business and digital innovation, which supported digital entrepreneurship in Burkina Faso alongside Ghana, Senegal and Morocco, ran to 2022 and has closed. At home, a draft startup law offering tax relief and easier formalities was validated with its implementing decree in July 2025, beside a FCFA 10bn Burkina Start Up fund running since 2017.

Capacity

Literacy

Burkina Faso ranks second to last in the world on ICT skills (2023), and the digital literacy sub-score in UNCDF's Inclusive Digital Economy Scorecard stood at 9% (2020). That is the floor under every service the state is now moving online.

The schooling beneath it is thin at both ends. The country scores 25.7 out of 100 on education enrolment, 46th of 54 African countries, 26.5 on education quality, 43rd, and 39.7 on education completion, a score that fell over 2014-2023 (2023). What the system scores well on is staffing: on the same index Human Resources in Education is Burkina Faso's second best-scoring indicator of all, at 90.6 and 16th of 54, up 10.4 points over 2014-2023 (2023). Provision has also grown more equal, with equality in education up 14.2 points to 52.2, 24th of 54 (2023). Staffed schools, in a system whose completion score is falling.

The pupils are about to be counted. A national pupil file with online enrolment and school identity cards was under review in June 2025, progressive enrolment due from the following school year.

Adult work on the literacy that digital systems actually demand runs largely through payments. The national inclusive finance agency and Wave Burkina opened a financial education and consumer protection campaign at Bobo-Dioulasso on 28 July 2026, part of a partnership running since 2025 that is being extended in 2026 to Ouagadougou, Bobo-Dioulasso, Kaya and Tenkodogo, with 72 hours of sessions on budgeting, savings, credit and consumer protection and participants going back to their communities as relays.

Training and skills

The state charges its own staff to learn. Burkina Faso's digital skills programme for public servants offers its training on a fee-paying basis and reaches only strategy or programme level, covering basic digital skills and data literacy (2025).

Institution-building has moved faster than instruction. The Conseil des ministres adopted the statutes of the Académie technologique du Faso on 23 July 2026, and a week later a Répertoire général des métiers de la formation professionnelle covering 14 priority sectors, digital transition among them (30 July 2026).

What reaches serving officials is episodic and small. Senior staff of the Ministry of Territorial Administration were trained in personal data protection in July 2025, extending compliance work into the ministry that runs local administration, and the Prime Minister's office ran a two-day session for its own senior staff on management tools for the ethical and responsible use of artificial intelligence on 13-14 July 2026. The national artificial-intelligence roadmap is meant to build national skills in artificial intelligence, data science and emerging technologies (June 2026).

Much of the rest has been donor-carried and is running out. A UNDP project with the government, covering digital skills alongside digital inclusion and ICT policy, runs to 2026, and Enabel's Digital for Girls and Women project, which put digital skills and digital rights awareness to girls and women, closed in 2025. Outside the state there are innovation hubs and fab labs such as OuagaLab, InViis Lab and La Fabrique (2023).

Research institutions

The country's visible research capacity in digital sits in one place. The Centre d'excellence en Intelligence Artificielle pour le Développement (CITADEL), at the Université Virtuelle du Burkina Faso, won competitive international funding from Canada's International Development Research Centre, and a second phase oriented to research and action began in April 2025. Alongside it, a ministry workshop in March 2026 set out to build large-language-model data corpora in Mooré, Dioula, Fulfuldé and Gulmancema for speech recognition, automatic translation and voice synthesis.

Inclusion

Access to services

Burkina Faso ranks fifth on the continent for whether public services reach all groups and regions on equal terms, scoring 61.6 out of 100 on the Ibrahim Index, 5th of 54, though the score fell 6.5 points over 2014-2023 (2023). That is evenness, not level, and the legal machinery behind it has not moved: Protection against Discrimination is among the country's ten worst-scoring indicators at 16.7 out of 100, 23rd of 54, with no change at all over the same decade (2023).

In practice the question is what a person must hold before the counter will serve them. A national identity card is required to open a bank account (2025), while the law requires no birth certificate for access to public health services (2017). The card is not free (2025). Distance decides the rest: civil registration outside the towns is still done on paper, and parents in remote areas can spend days reaching an office (2024); nearly four in ten births are not declared within the legal deadline (2024).

One fee is written off by group. Under article 8 of the access-to-information law, a person living with disability pays nothing where the information requested concerns their educational, professional or social integration. The same law admits a verbal request but allows appeal to its oversight authority only against a decision on a written request or a transcribed verbal one, so an untranscribed verbal request carries no remedy.

Where the channel is digital it is thin. The national government service portal remains informational only (2025) and there is no central grievance or feedback platform for public services at all (2025). The public-service ministry launched a complaints platform, plaintes.gov.bf, in March 2019, and the repository holds no later account of it; the dysfunctions regulation commission opened DenonciationPro for confidential reports of misconduct in the administration in February 2026. On the payments side the state's own promotion agency makes the sharper point: financial inclusion does not stop at an account or a transfer but takes in savings, credit and insurance (July 2026).

Digital divides

Geography divides hardest: grid electricity reaches most urban households and almost no rural ones (2023), and the state had to put more than 3 billion CFA francs into restoring networks in areas destabilised by insecurity (March 2025). The universal-service response has been slow against the size of the problem: ARCEP's programme cleared several hundred mobile white zones in its first phase, through 183 new sites (2022), with thousands of localities still dark, and connectivity was extended to 370 additional localities during 2025. Price draws the second line: mobile internet costs a substantially higher share of income here than the African average (2025).

Burkinabè rate the infrastructure around them markedly better than they did a decade ago: the Ibrahim Index's Public Perception of Infrastructure score rose 9.3 points over 2014-2023 to 30.5 out of 100, 26th of 54 (2023). That is movement off a floor rather than arrival anywhere, and it is the pattern across the whole set: the same index's Internet & Computers measure is among the country's most improved indicators while its score stays at 24.3 out of 100 (2023).

Work aimed at the gender divide is thin and mostly finishing. Enabel's Digital for Girls and Women project closed in 2025, and UNDP's inclusive digital transformation project with the government runs only to 2026; what is live is small, such as the financial-literacy programme Wave runs with the national inclusive-finance agency, aimed at rural women (July 2026). Disability appears mainly as a future obligation: the commitment on the record is to write a gender and disability-inclusion lens into an updated digital transformation strategy (2025). Language is the divide the state has moved on most deliberately, with a March 2026 ministry workshop to build large-language-model corpora in Mooré, Dioula, Fulfuldé and Gulmancema so that services reach citizens who do not speak French.

Data

National statistics

The general business census run in 2024 and published in May 2026 counted 389,172 economic units, 96.5% of them operating informally. Against that, Burkina Faso has run no business or establishment survey in the past ten years, and its most recent agricultural census falls only within the last twenty, though a population census and repeated household and health surveys fall inside the decade to 2023.

The system runs on loi n° 036-2021 of 6 December 2021, which abrogates the 2007 statistics law by name and by number. Any survey or census collecting individual data, public or private or run by an international organisation, needs a visa statistique from the minister before it may go into the field, and an operation without one is suspended by the minister, its results struck with nullity by his decision rather than by a court. Answering is a criminal obligation: refusal without legitimate motive, or knowingly incomplete answers, carries three months' imprisonment and a fine of 150,000 to 2,000,000 FCFA, and the procès-verbaux reach the Procureur du Faso by way of the minister's desk. The same law obliges the authorities to work free of political power and interest groups and to publish to a calendar announced in advance, while letting certain authorities receive statistics early under embargo, and defers its operating detail to regulation at least five times.

Capacity of the Statistical System is the ninth most improved indicator of the decade in the country's governance profile, up 16.5 points over 2014-2023 to 44.7 out of 100 and still 31st of 54 (2023). The 2023 statistical performance reading splits the same way: data use scores above 89% while data sources score only 20-49%, the weakest of the five pillars. That thinness shows at the bottom of the chain, where primary school directors complete paper forms on a fixed statistical day for keying in at regional level, clinics summarise paper registers onto monthly forms for district teams to enter into DHIS2, and the country keeps no continuously updated population register. Its national statistical yearbook for 2024, published in December 2025, compiles returns from population and justice to telecommunications, prices and public debt. The institute's 2026-2030 plan sets out platforms to exploit administrative data, civil registration included, for demographic statistics disaggregated below national level.

Open data

Burkina Faso publishes its agriculture statistics in full and its digital ones not at all: in the 2024 Open Data Inventory agriculture scores 10 out of 10, education outcomes 8.5 and national accounts 8, while the digital category scores zero and population statistics, labour, crime and health outcomes 5 each.

The right to ask has been on the books since loi n° 051-2015/CNT of 30 August 2015, which makes public information and administrative documents communicable of right from any organisme de service public. A body must answer within twenty days, extendable once by ten, and every refusal must be reasoned and cite the provision relied on. Nothing may be charged for lodging a request or for the body's search time, and electronic delivery is free where the document already exists in electronic form.

The statistics institute has gone the other way for its own data: its open data licence grants free, worldwide reuse, commercial reuse included, with attribution (October 2026), its open data portal was being migrated to the African Development Bank's version 2.0 in February 2025, and a university artificial-intelligence centre's decision-data portal held 147 datasets with no public API in June 2026.

The sharpest penalty in the statute falls on those who reuse public data, not on officials who withhold it. Commercial reuse without prior authorisation and payment of the royalty carries two to five years' imprisonment and a fine of 100,000 to 1,000,000 FCFA, a for-profit company being fined 5 per cent of its last closed turnover; an official who obstructs access faces an administrative ladder from a letter of explanation to revocation, criminal prosecution being left to the archives law and the penal code. One article withholds whole classes of information without a harm test, among them government deliberations, defence, state security, public order and international relations, and personal files and census or survey records carrying personal detail stay closed for fifty years. A verbal request is admitted, but only a decision on a written or transcribed one can be appealed to the oversight authority, and the oversight authority issues only an avis, binding relief lying with the administrative tribunal.

Disclosure of Public Records, up 23.0 points over the decade to 41.9 out of 100 and 16th of 54 (2023), is the third most improved indicator in the country's profile, and Accessibility of Public Records stands at 48.8, 10th of 54. An Open Government Partnership commitment covers publishing ministry data in open formats, and a government open data portal carrying a comprehensive data catalogue, updated weekly or daily, was in place in 2025.

Use of satellite data

The national statistics institute put a geospatial analysis of its Système d'Information des Localités to validation in September 2025. Burkina Faso had adopted no national space or Earth observation policy as at August 2026. Use runs through services rather than policy: the GARBAL call service, built on satellite data and the meteorological agency's forecasts, had more than 260,000 users and about two million calls by mid-2024.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

The American presence in Burkina Faso's digital sector is a training programme rather than a system. The United States ambassador announced a major digitalisation and artificial-intelligence training initiative for 2026, to run in American spaces in Ouagadougou, Bobo-Dioulasso and Koudougou (January 2026). No US hyperscaler cloud region, data centre or platform agreement holding Burkinabè government or citizen data was on record as at August 2026.

China activities

A Chinese vendor sits in the travel-document layer of the identity system: Burkina Faso's passport is supplied by Emptech (2025). That is a procurement relationship and not an operating one.

Chinese state lenders are the largest bilateral source of digital financing to the country (2026), on two commitments: China Eximbank's RMB 560 million concessional loan for Smart Burkina Faso, and Bank of China's USD 77.35 million buyer's credit for the national fibre backbone. Together they are roughly two-fifths of all recorded digital financing commitments to Burkina Faso. Both build fibre, and both name Huawei as contractor.

EU activities

The European Union's country programme buys digital only as a side-effect of buying something else: the 2021-2027 Multiannual Indicative Programme lists « Numérique – digitalisation » among its transversal themes, beside human rights, gender and youth, migration, climate, civil society and culture, giving it no priority area and no allocation of its own. Digital regulation and regional digital-market integration are pushed up to the EU's regional Multiannual Indicative Programme for sub-Saharan Africa rather than funded in the Burkina Faso programme. What digital content the programme has is what the sector envelopes buy: digitalisation along the criminal-justice chain, digital tools to improve the most vulnerable people's access to basic social services, and digital financial services and market-access platforms inside agri-food value chains.

The European work that does reach digital directly is small and mostly over. Enabel's Digital for Girls and Women project, on digital skills, digital rights awareness and gender-sensitive digital policy, closed in 2025, and the Agence Française de Développement's regional call on social business and digital innovation, which covered Burkina Faso alongside Ghana, Senegal and Morocco, closed in 2022. What continues is municipal: the EU is backing Ouagadougou's street-addressing programme, extended to arrondissements 5 and 12 in April 2025 to build an address database for public services.

Gulf/UAE activities

Burkina Faso's one Gulf digital agreement is a memorandum, not an investment: on 19 September 2025 in Abu Dhabi the digital transition minister signed a memorandum of understanding with Presight International Services, a subsidiary of the UAE's G42 Group, covering artificial intelligence skills, digital infrastructure, e-government services and cybersecurity. No Gulf investment, data-centre or platform presence in the country was on record as at September 2026.

India activities

India's relationship with Burkina Faso is substantial and almost entirely non-digital. Its Ministry of External Affairs records a 1994 Joint Commission agreement, ITEC and ICCR training cooperation, lines of credit including US$25 million for rural electrification signed on 29 March 2013, India-Africa Forum grant projects, trade figures and high-level visits (April 2026); the one digital item in it is Burkina Faso's inclusion in the Pan African e-Network Project.

Digital sovereignty

Burkina Faso's prime minister directed the administration in February 2026 to adopt sovereign digital tools for email and for document management and sharing, replacing third-party solutions progressively, after the 2025 finance law had set 4.09 billion FCFA to clear arrears under the state's Microsoft agreement.

Where state data sits is governed by instruction rather than statute: a prime-ministerial circular tells state bodies to favour national hosting (March 2026), while the personal-data law adopted on 3 August 2026 bars transferring sensitive personal data abroad. The registers are moving onto state premises: the two administration data centres inaugurated in January 2026 are to hold identity, civil-status, public-finance, health and security data under national control, run by Burkinabè engineers, with a further national data centre planned for 2028.

Control of the systems is written into procurement. Any platform the administration paid for must have full rights in its source code and documentation assigned to the state before it goes live, and the director-general of digital transformation says the state now refuses black-box platforms and requires skills transfer so ministries can maintain a system after the project ends (March 2026). Enrolment for the unique identifier is reserved to public bodies so that fingerprint and iris data stay in national custody (July 2026), though identity-card production relied on a Canadian firm for remote assistance and training (2017).

The terms on which the Microsoft agreement, the September 2025 memorandum with Presight, a G42 subsidiary, and Cybastion's August 2025 modular data-centre deal govern data jurisdiction, portability and exit had not been published as at September 2026.

The regional layer is the Sahel confederation: Mali's national data centre, opened in early 2026 before the AES digital ministers, is to host shared AES infrastructure in the short term.

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